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The Portrait of a Lady

- Khushwant Singh

The story is an autobiographical account that explored the author's evolving relationship with his grandmother, highlighting the changes that occur as he grows up and moves away for his studies.

Poetic device:-

① Simile:

Ex- she looked like a statue; The old women's eyes were like stars.

② Metaphor:

Ex- My grandmother's face was a map of wrinkles; the world seem to shrink into the four walls of the room.

③ Personification:

Ex- The house sigh; The memories whispered.

④ Hyperbolic:

Ex- She was the most beautiful woman in the world; I felt like I was a million miles away.

Theme:-

"The Portrait of a Lady" by Khushwant Singh revolves around love, attachment and passage of time. The story highlights the deep bond between the narrator and his grandmother who is portrait as a symbol of tradition, simplicity and unconditional love.

Multiple Choice Questions:-

- Q1 what would the grandmother do in the temple on daily basis?
- (i) Meditate (iii) Sing Religious Prayers
(ii) Read Scriptures ✓ (iv) Teach other kids
- Q2 what did the author eat for breakfast?
- (i) Bread with Butter (iii) Upma
(ii) Curd & Rice (iv) Thick stale chappaties with sugar & butter ✓

Short Answer Questions:

- Q1 How did the grandmother keeps her self busy?
- Ans She kept herself busy with prayer, telling beads of her rosary, feeding dogs in the village, and later feeding sparrows in the city.

- Q1 when was the only time the grandmother did not pray?
- Ans The only time the grandmother did not pray was when she celebrated the narrator's return from abroad. She gathered women, sang songs, beat a drum, and rejoiced instead of praying.

- Q2 How did the grandmother see off her grandson at the station?
- Ans She saw him off silently at the railway station, without emotion or words, just lips moving in prayer and rosary beads in her hand.

Long Answer Questions

Q1. Not only human beings but birds also express emotions. Comment on the statement in the view of the story 'The portrait of a lady'.

Ans. In 'The Portrait of a Lady', Khushwant Singh shows that emotions are not confined to humans. When the grandmother died, thousands of sparrows sit quietly around the house and courtyard. They neither chirp nor make noise, but mourn in deep silence. Their grief was so profound that they refused food and flew away quietly the next morning. This silent mourning reflects genuine sorrow, providing that birds too can feel and express emotions. The sparrow's behaviour symbolized nature's bond with the grandmother, highlighting her purity and spiritual life. Thus, the story beautifully illustrates that love, loss, and mourning transcend species, and even birds share emotional connections with humans.

Key Points:

- * The narrator shared a close bond with his religious grandmother in his childhood.
- * She took care of him and taught him prayers.
- * Their relationship weakens as he joins an English school in the city.
- * She spends her old age in prayer and solitude feeding sparrows.
- * When he returns from abroad, she falls ill.
- * She died peacefully accepting death calmly.
- * Sparrows gather silently symbolizing love and mourning.

Word Meanings:-

1. Mantelpiece: A structure of wood, marble or stone above and around the fireplace.
2. Fables: Fictional theories with a moral learning.
3. Beads of Rosary: A string of beads for keeping account of chants for prayer.
4. Buckle-eyed: A face contracted into "winkled".

Ans
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Exercise

I Identify the tenses in the following sentences:-

1 She was old.
~~Ans~~ Simple past

2 She had been old and wrinkled for the past 20 years I had known her.
~~Ans~~ Past Perfect

3 She was presiding the prayers.
~~Ans~~ Past Continuous

4 She feed the sparrows.
~~Ans~~ ?

5 By that time she had become very frail.
~~Ans~~ ?

6 She was telling the bead of Rosary.
~~Ans~~ Past continuous

7 I went to the University
~~Ans~~ Simple Past